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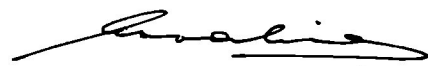
From the editor-in-chief

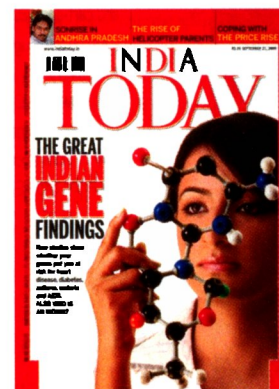
Lost your eyesight because of a road accident? Don't despair, for you could actually repair your damaged cornea through the new miracle cure: stem cells. For the last decade, the scientific world has been galvanised by stem cell research. Stem cells are the building blocks of the human body and when extracted, can potentially be made to grow into any cell in the body, making them an extraordinary resource in the fight against cardiovascular disease, spinal injuries, corneal damage and many others. A cell that has the potential to regenerate tissue over a lifetime holds out exciting possibilities. That, of course, is the crux of the stem cell story: the hope versus the hype. In terms of research and actual application, it is still relatively new but that it has enormous potential to save lives cannot be in doubt. While the ethical controversy of harvesting stem cells from human embryos has raged for over a decade, scientists are finding ways of securing these master cells from regular tissue like skin that are silencing critics and opening new doors.

Today, stem cell research is expanding into the broader field of regenerative medicine and therapeutic uses. That is something which is energising scientists and doctors across India. Thanks to pro-active policies and funding, India is at the cutting edge of stem cell research and therapy. Hyderabad's L.V. Prasad Eye Institute, using stem cells taken from the eyes of patients, has successfully treated over 700 of them having serious corneal injuries. At Delhi's All India Institute of Medical Sciences, over 100 patients suffering from heart attacks and certain cardiovascular diseases have shown significant improvement in their condition after being treated with stem cells extracted from their own bone marrow.

There are now over 18 hospitals across the country that are treating patients using stem cells for such diseases and ailments such as liver failure, spinal injuries caused through accidents, strokes of various kinds and blood cancer. The Department of Biotechnology is now funding major clinical trials in premier institutes to see the efficacy of stem cell treatment before clearing it for widespread use. It has so far released over Rs 300 crore for stem cell research, showing how serious the Government is about the treatment and potential. It has also formulated strict guidelines to keep out fly-by-night operators.

The excitement is palpable, as Managing Editor Raj Chengappa, who put the cover story together, found when he spoke to key researchers and doctors. So much so that many Indians have already started paying over Rs 1 lakh to have their babies' stem cells extracted from the umbilical cord and stored, an indication of just how promising the therapy is, although doubts and controversies remain. The jury may be out but the potential is so enormous and exciting that we decided to focus on just how much stem cell science has progressed in India both in research and its therapeutic uses, the success stories, what the future looks like as well as the possible dangers.


(Aroon Purie)



OUR SEPTEMBER 2009 COVER